

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Joshua 1:1-2

Moses had died on Mount Nebo east of the Jordan ([Deut 34:1-5](#)).

Joshua 1:1-9

God confirmed Joshua as Israel's leader and Moses' successor. God made Abraham a specific promise to bring his descendants into possession of the land of Canaan ([Gen 12:7](#); [15:7](#); [17:8](#)). This promise was repeated to Moses ([Exod 3:6-8](#); [13:3-5](#); [Deut 1:6-8](#); [6:10-19](#)). Now God was ready to fulfill his promise using Joshua. Joshua led Israel's first generation of settlers into the Promised Land, and his victories against two Canaanite coalitions—first in the south and then in the north—opened the hill country for settlement by the Israelites.

Joshua 1:3

Moses' death did not end God's presence with or guidance of Israel.

Joshua 1:4

Ancient Israel's southernmost settlement was in the Negev, in the vicinity of Beersheba ([15:28](#)). Israel's northernmost tribes settled in portions of the Lebanon mountains, which made them neighbors of the Sidonians. • The Hittites were one of the subgroups that made up Canaan's population (see study note on 3:10).

Joshua 1:5

God promised never to fail or abandon Joshua, just as he had promised Moses (cp. [Deut 31:6-8](#)).

Joshua 1:6

you are the one: God delegated Joshua as the primary agent to fulfill the promise he had given to their ancestors (see [Exod 6:8](#)).

Joshua 1:6-9

For emphasis, God told Joshua three times that he would need to be strong and courageous in order to be successful against the Canaanites, who outnumbered Israel. The people would also need to be careful to obey all the instructions Moses had given them if Israel were to settle the land, establish productive farms, and build homes, villages, and cities. The land is God's land, as is the whole earth ([Ps 24:1](#)); God brought Israel into Canaan as tenants, not as owners ([Lev 25:23](#)).

Joshua 1:8

This Book of Instruction (Hebrew torah) probably refers to the book of Deuteronomy (see [Deut 4:44](#); [29:21](#); [30:10](#); [31:9-12](#)). It includes Israel's foundational law codes as well as God's moral and spiritual instructions. • God commanded Joshua to think and speak of God's instruction day and night—i.e., continually (cp. [Deut 6:6-7](#); [17:18-20](#)).

Joshua 1:9

As the Israelites entered Canaan, they would fight the worshipers of the Canaanite gods, but they were afraid these gods would grant the Canaanites victory in battle. In reassuring Joshua, God used his personal name the Lord (Hebrew Yahweh; see study note on Exod 3:15) to remind Joshua that the Lord was more powerful than any false gods the Canaanites might invoke. • your God is with you: God's continuous presence made it possible for Joshua to heed God's instruction.

Joshua 1:10

commanded: Joshua now began leading God's people.

Joshua 1:11

Because of fear and unbelief, the previous generation had refused to enter the Promised Land from the south forty years earlier (see [Num 13-14](#)). The current generation would now enter from the east, across the Jordan River.

Joshua 1:12-15

Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh had requested and received from Moses the conquered land east of the Jordan ([Num 32:33](#)).

Joshua 1:13

God wanted the people of Israel to experience the spiritual, cultural, and emotional rest of a right relationship with him and each other, not just the physical rest of living in a secure and abundant land (see [Heb 4:1-11](#)).

Joshua 1:14

The warriors of the 2½ tribes had promised to cross the Jordan with the rest of Israel to help them conquer their land ([Num 32:16-19](#)). Joshua reminded them of their obligation.

Joshua 1:17

Israel often did not obey . . . Moses. However, the tribes living east of the Jordan did cross with the rest of Israel, and they did not return to their own land and homes until Joshua dismissed them ([22:6](#)).

Joshua 1:18

Disobeying God's chosen ruler was treason against God himself.

Joshua 2:1

Acacia Grove was about eight miles east of the Jordan River on the plains of Moab, across from

Jericho (see [Num 25:1](#)). • In the house of a prostitute strangers could avoid unwanted attention. According to tradition, Rahab was an innkeeper as well as a prostitute (Josephus, *Antiquities* 5.1.2). Other evidence from the ancient Near East suggests that women who owned and operated inns were often prostitutes.

Joshua 2:1-24

Like any good military commander, Joshua sent out spies or scouts to get information about his objective. • Because Israel planned to approach Canaan from the east, they could not bypass Jericho.

Joshua 2:2

The spies' speech probably gave them away. Hebrew and Canaanite were both dialects of the same language but with differences in vocabulary and grammar.

Joshua 2:3

Jericho's king assumed Rahab was both loyal to the city and unaware of the men's mission.

Joshua 2:4-5

It is not necessary either to condone or condemn Rahab's lying to the king's messengers. She might have had no concept of any ethical standards God had given Israel. Or the higher ethical value of saving lives might supersede the normal requirement to be truthful.

Joshua 2:6

The inner fibers of flax were processed to make linen. The first step involved laying out the flax stems to dry on the flat rooftop.

Joshua 2:7

Medium-sized towns such as Jericho had one main gate made of two very large wooden doors

reinforced with bronze. The gate was barred for the night and opened again in the morning. By shutting the gate immediately after the pursuers departed, the authorities took a sensible precaution: If the spies had not left the town as Rahab implied, they might still be found in Jericho during the night.

Joshua 2:9–10

Rahab began to declare her faith in the Lord. • made a dry path: God had parted the waters of the Red Sea for Israel ([Exod 14:21–28](#)). • Israel had defeated Sihon and Og ([Num 21:21–35](#)). • completely destroyed: See [Lev 27:28–29](#); [1 Sam 15:3](#).

Joshua 2:11

Although the people of Canaan incurred God's judgment, Rahab's declaration of faith (proven genuine by her aid to the spies) brought her into the people of God ([Heb 11:31](#)).

Joshua 2:12–13

Rahab's request demonstrated her faith in Israel and Israel's God.

Joshua 2:14

When Israel attacked Jericho, Joshua and the two spies kept their promise to spare Rahab ([6:22](#)).

Joshua 2:15

Because Rahab's house stood on the town wall, she could hide the men on the flat roof of her house ([2:6](#)) and let them out through the window, down the outer side of the wall.

Joshua 2:16

The hill country of central Canaan began its steep rise just west of Jericho. Thinking that the two spies would head directly to Israel's camp across the Jordan, the pursuers from Jericho would naturally

head eastward. When the pursuers gave up, the spies could slip across the Jordan unhindered.

Joshua 2:19

it will not be our fault. But . . . we will accept the responsibility: The spies used a standard formula to accept responsibility for any of Rahab's family remaining with her in her house, but not for those who did not.

Joshua 2:23–24

The spies' report surely raised the spirits and morale of the Israelites.

Joshua 3:1

Israel had camped at Acacia Grove since before Balaam's oracles ([Num 22–24](#)).

Joshua 3:3

The Ark of the Covenant of the Lord was God's dwelling place among the Israelites and symbolized his throne. Whenever Israel moved, a contingent of priests carried the Ark before them ([Exod 25:13–15](#); [Num 10:33–36](#)).

Joshua 3:4

Stay about half a mile behind them: God did not want his people to take his presence for granted. They were to acknowledge his holiness with reverence, respect, and awe.

Joshua 3:5

Purify yourselves: They had to separate themselves from anything unclean that would bar an Israelite from coming into God's presence (cp. [Exod 19:9–20](#); [Lev 11:44](#)).

Joshua 3:7

To reassure the people that he had not brought them this far to abandon them, God made Joshua a great leader like Moses.

Joshua 3:8

As they crossed the Jordan River, the Ark led the way until the feet of the priests entered the water; the priests were to stand in the Jordan, not on the dry land. By carrying the Ark into the water first, the obedient priests would show their faith (cp. [Jas 2:18](#)).

Joshua 3:10

Today you will know: The Israelites who were adults when Moses led Israel out of Egypt had died. The people now entering Canaan with Joshua had taken their place. The events about to unfold would signify God's presence with them and demonstrate his intention to fulfill his promises. • In Canaan, the Israelites would be living among pagan neighbors and might be tempted to join them in worshiping their gods and goddesses. None of these false gods were worthy of worship. By contrast, the Lord is the living God, and he was present among the Israelites. • The Canaanites and Amorites were distinct peoples, but their names sometimes indicated all the pre-Israelite peoples of Canaan. The Hittites were related to the earlier Hittite Empire of Asia Minor that controlled much of Canaan. The Jebusites were from the city-state of Jerusalem, which Israel did not conquer fully until David's time. Little is known about the other three groups.

Joshua 3:11

Because the Ark of the Covenant went ahead of the Israelites, they knew that the Lord of the whole earth was leading them into Canaan. Their God was not a limited local deity.

Joshua 3:12

Joshua told the people to choose twelve men but did not reveal what this group of men would be doing ([4:2-8](#)).

Joshua 3:13

Even though the Jordan was in its spring flood stage, the water stopped abruptly, an obvious miracle.

Joshua 3:15

The Jordan was overflowing its banks as a result of the spring runoff of the winter's rainfall and snowfall, especially from Mount Hermon.

Joshua 3:16

Two wonders occurred. First, the water . . . began backing up above Adam (about twenty-five miles away). Second, the entire bed of the river was dry, as remaining water drained to the Dead Sea.

Joshua 3:17

The repetition of the phrase on dry ground emphasizes that God performed a miracle.

Joshua 4:2

The twelve men represented Jacob's twelve sons. The tribe of Levi was not counted because the Levites settled in designated cities among the other tribes ([Gen 49:5-7](#); [Num 1:49-52](#); [18:20](#)). However, the number of tribes remained at twelve because Joseph's two sons (Ephraim and Manasseh) were accounted as separate tribes ([Gen 48:5](#)).

Joshua 4:5

Carrying the stone on a shoulder implies that the men each chose stones weighing some 100 pounds.

Joshua 4:6

Joshua twice ([4:21](#)) told the Israelites to prepare to answer future generations. The stone memorial would serve as a teaching aid.

Joshua 4:9

A second memorial of twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan was submerged as soon as the river resumed its flow. The monument's top would be visible in the dry summer seasons. • Their existence to this day indicates that the memorials stood for generations, until the final editing of the book (see Joshua Book Introduction, "Author and Date").

Joshua 4:14

Now that God had brought the Israelites safely across the Jordan River, Israel recognized God's presence with Joshua as a great leader and revered him as much as they had revered Moses. Their confidence in Joshua would be crucial in the years ahead.

Joshua 4:18

After Israel crossed the river, the Jordan overflowed its banks as before. These events could not occur without God's intervention.

Joshua 4:19–20

The tenth day of the first month occurred a few days before Passover. • Gilgal became an important worship center for early Israel. Although its location is uncertain, it was somewhere just east or northeast of Jericho. Its name (which means "wheel of a cart," cp. [Isa 28:28](#)) implies that Joshua set the twelve stones in a circle (cp. study note on Josh 5:9).

Joshua 4:24

In addition to future generations of Israelites, all the nations of the earth were to understand God's power. At least some individuals in every group respond to the God who cares for them ([Rev 7:9–10](#)).

Joshua 5:1

After news of Israel's crossing of the Jordan River spread, all of southern Canaan was in a state of alert awaiting Israel's expected invasion. • With Israel's impossible crossing of the Jordan, the Canaanites lost heart and were paralyzed with fear. They knew they faced the people of a God more powerful than any they worshiped.

Joshua 5:2

Before the Israelites turned their attention to Jericho, God directed Joshua to perform the covenant renewal ceremony of circumcising all the males born in the forty years since the exodus from Egypt. Because the land was part of the covenant promise, Israel's men needed to demonstrate their personal participation in the covenant through circumcision in order to enter into the land. • Flint is found in a natural state, so flint knives were mandated for circumcision as a symbol of purity or holiness.

Joshua 5:3

The name Gibeath-haaraloth ("hill of foreskins") suggests that the circumcision ritual took place on a hill outside Israel's camp at Gilgal.

Joshua 5:4–7

This unexpected detour in the narrative provides an important reminder of Israel's earlier refusal to believe that God would bring them safely into the land of Canaan ([Num 14](#)). This summary of God's judgment upon their fathers reminded the present generation that trusting in God was still necessary if they were to occupy the land their ancestors had forfeited. Further, it signaled the completion of God's judgment upon the earlier generation.

Joshua 5:8

until they were healed: Recovery from circumcision, a relatively minor surgery, usually takes about three days if no complications occur.

Joshua 5:9

Gilgal sounds like the Hebrew word galal (“to roll”)—this place was where God rolled away the reproach of Egypt.

Joshua 5:10

The Passover lamb was slain on the evening of the fourteenth day of the first month. Just as the Passover in Egypt marked the exodus from slavery, the celebration of this Passover in Canaan marked the attainment of the goal God had been leading the Israelites toward. This Passover also anticipated God’s promised rest for his people in their new land. • This was apparently the first Passover Israel had celebrated since they had been encamped at Sinai ([Num 9:1–5](#)). For the younger Israelites, it was their first Passover ever; for the older ones, their first since childhood. Celebrating the Passover after such a long lapse, particularly on the eve of the campaign to take the Promised Land, heightened both the joy and the solemnity of the occasion.

Joshua 5:11

Israel reinstituted the Festival of Unleavened Bread, observed for seven days following Passover ([Lev 23:6](#)). The people ate unleavened bread and roasted grain, a favorite food of the harvest season (see [Ruth 2:14](#)).

Joshua 5:11–12

God’s daily provision of manna ([Exod 16:31](#); [Num 11:9](#)) could cease because the produce from the land was now available.

Joshua 5:12

Israel harvested the crops that the people of Jericho did not have time to harvest before Israel crossed the Jordan.

Joshua 5:13

Joshua was scouting the land and the city’s defenses near the town of Jericho to follow up on

the report of the two spies ([2:23–24](#)). Joshua demonstrated personal courage when he approached the unknown figure whose sword was already drawn.

Joshua 5:13–15

The commander of the Lord’s army gave Joshua instructions for conducting the siege of Jericho ([6:2–5](#)). Like God’s earlier message to Joshua ([1:1–9](#)), this encounter was to encourage Joshua on the eve of action against the enemy.

Joshua 5:14

Joshua fell with his face to the ground in reverence when he understood who stood before him. Joshua’s action demonstrated that he was available for God’s service, wholeheartedly and without reservation. • Scholars disagree whether the commander was an appearance of God, the pre-incarnate Christ, or an angel. His reference to himself as commander of the Lord’s army might imply that he was an angel. However, he did not prevent Joshua from worshipping him, as angels usually did (e.g., [Rev 22:8–9](#); cp. [Acts 10:25–26](#)).

Joshua 5:15

Take off your sandals, for the place . . . is holy: This was what God told Moses at the burning bush ([Exod 3:5](#)). Joshua certainly recognized the similarity. This encounter would have encouraged Joshua of God’s blessing on Israel’s first action against Canaan.

Joshua 6:1

Jericho guarded two important entrances into the heart of the hill country. If the Israelites did not conquer the city first, they would leave a well-armed enemy at their back, standing between the Israelite forces and their families encamped at Gilgal. They had to conquer Jericho first.

Joshua 6:2

God’s reassuring words, “I have given you Jericho,” must have lifted Joshua’s spirits. All Joshua had to

do was obey God, and he had a lifetime of practice at that.

Joshua 6:4

Seven is a biblical number of perfection. • The seven priests were to precede the Ark, the emblem of God's presence, at the head of Israel's forces. This arrangement symbolized that God himself fought against the town. Israel had only to march and observe, then shout and observe, and finally mop up after God delivered the town into their hands. • The ram's horn (Hebrew shofar) could sound several pitches to signal either battle or worship. In battle, the shofar alerted troops or townsfolk to an enemy's approach or sounded the call to advance or retreat.

Joshua 6:6-9

The Ark, the priests blowing the horns, and the military honor guard all symbolized God's presence and his leadership of the siege.

Joshua 6:10-11

Warriors would often shout in battle to lift their morale and intimidate the enemy. • until I tell you: After thirteen circuits of Jericho by Israel's army with only the sound of trumpets, the psychological shock when Jericho's defenders heard shouting would be devastating.

Joshua 6:15

Marching around Jericho seven times on the seventh day again symbolized that this was God's battle.

Joshua 6:16

Joshua's command, "Shout! For the Lord has given you the town!" was not a device to cause Jericho's walls to fall. Rather, Joshua exhorted the Israelites to celebrate God's victory.

Joshua 6:17

completely destroyed: Joshua reminded his troops that the town and everything in it belonged to God as the firstfruits of their inheritance in the land of Canaan. See [Lev 27:28-29](#); [1 Sam 15:3](#). • Rahab: See [Josh 2:12-21](#).

Joshua 6:20

Following Joshua's last-minute commands, a final blast of the rams' horns signaled the climax.

Joshua 6:22-23

The two spies fulfilled Joshua's command and their oath to Rahab. Through the actions of God's people, a pagan household saw that God is trustworthy. • the prostitute's house: See study note on 2:1. • Moving Rahab and her family near the camp of Israel provided security.

Joshua 6:24

The fire melted and purified the silver, gold, bronze, and iron. These metals had probably been used for the figures of pagan gods. As these images melted, the metals were purified and made fit for dedication to God.

Joshua 6:24-27

Jericho's citizens had already been executed ([6:21](#)). Now Joshua destroyed the town and its contents. The firstfruits of the spoils of war, as with all else, belonged to God.

Joshua 6:25

The statement that Rahab lives among the Israelites to this day affirms the breadth and depth of God's grace. Rahab was not only accepted into Israel; she ultimately was an ancestor of the Messiah (see [Matt 1:5](#)).

Joshua 6:26

Joshua placed a curse upon the site because Jericho was the first Canaanite town to resist God's purposes in bringing Israel into the land. Jericho was also the first town to experience God's judgment upon Canaan's great wickedness. As the firstfruits of Israel's conquest of Canaan, it belonged to God ([Exod 13:2](#); [23:19](#)). God executed Joshua's curse on the first man to defy it ([1 Kgs 16:34](#); cp. [Josh 7](#)).

Joshua 6:27

As the first chapter in Israel's conquest of Canaan closed, both the Israelites and the Canaanites could see that the Lord was with Joshua, as he had promised ([1:5](#), [9](#); cp. [4:14](#)). Crossing the Jordan and taking Jericho established Israel's presence in the land, causing the people of Canaan to fear Israel and Israel's God.

Joshua 7:1

- *things devoted to destruction*: See [Leviticus 27:28–29](#); [1 Samuel 15:3](#).
- *son of Zerah*: Achan was part of an important family. He was a leader or potential leader, so his actions could influence others ([Numbers 26:19–20](#)).

Joshua 7:1–26

Now that Jericho belonged to Israel, Joshua's first military problem involved securing a foothold in the hill country. The conquest of Jericho inspired Israel's confidence and consigned the people of Canaan to discouragement and despair. Yet everything hinged on Israel's obedience to God. One man's sin and its consequences demonstrate how serious was the command to destroy Jericho (see "Complete Dedication" Theme Note).

Joshua 7:1–12.24

This second major section of the book includes a record of Joshua's southern and northern campaigns against two coalitions of Canaanite kings. Joshua's victories enabled Israel to settle the

hill country from Galilee in the north to the Negev in the south.

Joshua 7:2

As he did before the battle for Jericho, Joshua sent some of his men to assess the situation at Ai. This town stood about ten miles west of Jericho at the entrance to a plateau north of Jerusalem called the Plateau of Benjamin; conquering Ai would open the way for Israel to control the hill country. • Beth-aven, "house of iniquity," was probably an intentionally derogatory wordplay on the name Bethel, the "house of God." A pagan shrine stood on this site later in Israel's history ([1 Kgs 12:28–33](#)).

Joshua 7:3–4

God's provision of victory at Jericho apparently bred complacency and overconfidence; Joshua did not even consult with God before sending a small contingent of troops to Ai.

Joshua 7:5

Ai's defenders left through the town gate and attacked Israel's troops directly (see [8:5](#)). • as far as the quarries: An otherwise unknown place.

Joshua 7:6

Israel's leaders tore their clothing and threw dust on their heads, common public gestures of grief or despair in the ancient Near East. By falling face down before the Ark of the Lord, Joshua belatedly acknowledged that Israel needed God's direction in the battle against Ai.

Joshua 7:7

Joshua expressed his anger toward God; this explains the sharp tone of God's reply ([7:10–15](#)). Though the battle had been lost because of Achan's sin, Joshua and Israel's elders had neglected to seek God's guidance ([7:3](#)). • Joshua did not really believe that Israel should have stayed on the other side of the Jordan. Rather, he used hyperbole to show that he was at a loss over what to do next.

Joshua 7:8-9

Joshua's fears were realistic. All Canaan had thought that Israel was invincible. However, because tiny Ai had defeated Israel, the Canaanites might think it could happen again. • If God allowed the wicked to wipe his people off the face of the earth, the nations would not have a witness that God continues to be involved with his world. • your great name: Cp. [Exod 32:11-12](#); [Num 14:13-19](#).

Joshua 7:10-11

Get up! God's command was abrupt, stern, and outwardly unsympathetic. For Israel to regain God's favor, Joshua needed to act swiftly and decisively.

Joshua 7:12

Israel itself has been set apart for destruction: With his individual sin, Achan made all Israel liable to destruction.

Joshua 7:13

Command the people to purify themselves: See study note on 3:5.

Joshua 7:14

Israel's twelve tribes were descendants of Jacob's sons. A clan represented a smaller unit within the tribes; later, as Israel's allotments in the land were distributed, a clan usually received possession of a town and its surrounding fields, forest, and pastureland. A man's family included his sons and their dependents.

Joshua 7:15

God had commanded that all the stolen goods were to be destroyed by fire. Now they would be, because Achan and everything he had would be burned with fire. Breaking the covenant of the Lord was treason, a capital offense (e.g., [Exod 22:20](#); [Deut 4:25-27](#)).

Joshua 7:16-18

Achan might have been singled out by use of the Urim and Thummim, a God-given system of sacred lots. These items remained in the care of the high priest, probably in a bag or a pouch (see [Exod 28:30](#); [Num 27:21](#)). They might have been two different-colored objects, perhaps stones or gems. Inquiries were phrased as "yes" or "no" questions.

Joshua 7:19-20

My son: This gentle, compassionate form of address reveals Joshua as a caring leader, sorry for this young man trapped by impulsive greed. Although Joshua and Achan both knew that Achan would die for his crime, Joshua entreated him to repent. Achan responded with a full confession.

Joshua 7:21

The robe should have been burned with the rest of Jericho's goods. It was from Babylon, evidence that long-distance trade was a significant part of life in the ancient Near East. • 200 silver coins: Achan took pieces or lumps of silver that functioned as money; coinage *per se* was not invented until the 600s BC. • I wanted them so much is translated "covet" in the tenth commandment ([Exod 20:17](#)). Achan's coveting had prompted his theft.

Joshua 7:22

Because the matter was urgent, Joshua's messengers ran to the tent to confirm Achan's confession.

Joshua 7:24

This careful listing of Achan's relatives and possessions, including the stolen items, has the tone of a legal statement. Achan compromised all that pertained to him through his contact with the stolen items; thus, all had to be included in his judgment.

Joshua 7:25

Stoning was one prescribed means of execution (see, e.g., [Exod 19:13](#)).

Joshua 7:26

God had not been angry without basis. God's people must be holy. To trifle with things belonging to God signifies rebellion against God, and such sin always brings trouble ('akor) upon God's people. Achan's sin brought disaster on Israel, so the severe punishment he received was just.

Joshua 8:1

Do not be afraid or discouraged: God gave Joshua similar encouragement before sending him against Jericho ([6:2](#)).

Joshua 8:1–13

The first attempt to conquer Ai had been done without consulting God; the second attempt would be made at God's command and direction. Before the second attempt, God spoke to Joshua again and gave him a strategy. More importantly, in light of Israel's recent disaster, God gave him encouragement and a promise.

Joshua 8:2

Unlike other ancient nations, who went to war to gain wealth, Israel served as God's agent of judgment upon the Canaanites; the plunder and the livestock were incidental. • The strategy for capturing Ai was to plan an ambush. Joshua executed God's simple instructions well. • behind the town: On its west side ([8:12](#)).

Joshua 8:3

set out to attack Ai: This first sentence provides a summary; details are filled in over the next several paragraphs. • The Hebrew words translated 30,000 might mean *30 units* (see study note on Exod 12:37) or *30 chieftains*. As the battle developed, this group would wait in ambush until Joshua called them out ([Josh 8:18–19](#)).

Joshua 8:4–9

Joshua told the select squad what to expect from Israel's main army. Because this special unit would be separated from Joshua's command for nearly forty-eight hours, they needed to understand exactly what to do. Israel's success in this second attempt on Ai depended on the precise timing of their rush into the town.

Joshua 8:11–13

That the main army marched in front of the town indicates that Joshua did not try to hide them from the defenders of Ai. The main army came from the east and ended the day camped on the north side of Ai. The men in ambush were west of Ai, between Ai and Bethel.

Joshua 8:14

The king of Ai . . . and all his army were recklessly eager to repeat their heroics of the previous battle. As Joshua and Israel had learned, such overconfidence is dangerous.

Joshua 8:15

Joshua and the Israelite army fled as in the first attack ([7:4–5](#)).

Joshua 8:17

not a man left in Ai or Bethel: Much of an individual soldier's gain from warfare was his share of the spoils taken from the defeated enemy or a reward given by his king for each enemy he killed. • The warriors of Bethel likely joined those of Ai because they also feared Israel's advance.

Joshua 8:18–19

Israel succeeded in this second attack on Ai because this time God directed the battle.

Joshua 8:28

Prior to its destruction, Ai was called by an unknown name. The writer of Joshua always referred to it as Ai (meaning “ruin”), the name it was given after its destruction.

Joshua 8:29

The public executions of the kings (see also [10:26](#); [11:10](#), [12](#)) emphasized that Israel was God’s agent in the judgment of the leaders and people of Canaan for their wickedness. • At sunset: See [Deut 21:22–23](#). • that can still be seen today: See Joshua Book Introduction, “Author and Date.”

Joshua 8:30–31

Archaeologists have recently discovered an altar . . . on Mount Ebal built of uncut stones and not shaped with iron tools. However, no inscription was found with it ([8:32](#)). • Burnt offerings and peace offerings were prescribed in the laws of sacrifice that God gave Moses while Israel was still at Mount Sinai ([Lev 1, 3](#)). Moses gave specific commands for this ceremony (see [Deut 11:26–32](#); [27:1–28:68](#)).

Joshua 8:32

Joshua fulfilled Moses’ command to set up stones and coat them with plaster ([Deut 27:2–8](#)). After the plaster hardened, the instructions (Hebrew torah) would permanently be on public display at the first location where Israel formally worshiped the Lord after entering the land. The public display of laws occurred in other places; the best-known example is the famous Code of Hammurabi, which that king set up in Babylon.

Joshua 8:33

The town of Shechem, located between Mount Gerizim to the south and Mount Ebal to the north, guarded the pass between the two mountains. Although the covenant renewal ceremony took place at Shechem, neither Joshua nor Judges records that Israel conquered the town. • With every Israelite involved and the Ark positioned in the valley between the two groups, this ceremony

was a promise to keep the covenant God had made with Israel at Sinai.

Joshua 8:33–35

This ceremony marked the formal possession of the land, even though major campaigns against the Canaanites were still to come. The ritual of sacrifice and reading of the law highlighted the promises and obligations of God’s covenant with them and anticipated the eventual possession of all of Canaan.

Joshua 8:34

blessings . . . curses: See [Deut 27–28](#).

Joshua 8:35

Old Testament religion was not just for the men of Israel; the entire assembly included the women and children. • The foreigners who lived among the Israelites included people who came out of Egypt with Israel in the Exodus ([Exod 12:38](#), [48–49](#)). These converts had accepted the Lord as their God and joined Israel when they saw the great things God had done for Israel.

Joshua 9:1

Hittites . . . Jebusites: See study note on 3:10. • The fertile region of lower hills between the highlands of Judah and the southern coastal plain was known as the western foothills. • Although not all of the coastal plain of the Mediterranean Sea was occupied during this period, several important cities did exist. The kings of those small city-states, as far north as Mount Carmel, joined the southern coalition to resist Israel’s advances.

Joshua 9:1–27

Joshua once again failed to consult God ([9:14](#); cp. [7:2–4](#)), this time over an unexpected request. Other ancient Near Eastern accounts tell only of a leader’s triumphs; this author also recorded the shortcomings of Joshua and Israel’s elders. The real hero of the story is God, whose accomplishments the author wished to tell.

Joshua 9:2

[Chapter 10](#) provides a more complete description of these kings and their reasons for forming a coalition to fight . . . the Israelites.

Joshua 9:3

The people of Gibeon deceitfully attempted to make a covenant with Israel. The town of Gibeon was on the plateau just north of Jerusalem (see study note on 7:2), not more than fifteen miles from Israel's camp at Gilgal.

Joshua 9:4–6

Long-distance travel was difficult, dirty, and dangerous in those days. If they were to carry off their deception, the Gibeonite supplies, clothes, and even food had to look the part.

Joshua 9:7–8

The name Hivites is known only from the Bible and refers to a non-Semitic ethnic group that lived in various parts of Canaan (see [Gen 34:2](#); [36:2](#); [Exod 23:23](#), [28](#)). • How do we know you don't live nearby? Israel's leaders raised the possibility of deception. Joshua followed the Gibeonites' evasive reply by asking two direct questions. However, Joshua could have received a direct answer by consulting the Lord ([Josh 9:14](#)).

Joshua 9:9–10

in Egypt: See [Exod 7–14](#). • kings . . . Sihon . . . Og: See [Num 21](#).

Joshua 9:11–13

Distracted by the flattering words about God and the notion that a foreign people wanted to make a treaty with them, none of Israel's leaders noticed that the Gibeonites had failed to answer Joshua's questions. • If the Israelites spared their lives, the Gibeonites were willing to be Israel's servants and swear to a treaty with Israel. This request should

have raised suspicions among Israel's leaders: Why would people from a distant land be concerned about a treaty of protection?

Joshua 9:14

Israel's leaders examined the bread to verify the Gibeonites' story, but Joshua neglected to consult the Lord. This same oversight had cost lives at Ai, whereas the victories at Jericho and Ai had both been won when Israel followed God's instructions precisely.

Joshua 9:15

Israel entered into a peace treaty with the Gibeonites. The Israelites were God's vassals, having entered into a suzerain-vassal treaty with God at Sinai (see study note on [Exod 20:1–23:33](#)). Israel did not have authority to enter into treaties without the approval of their own suzerain. • guaranteed their safety (literally *cut with them a covenant for their lives*): Nations ratified covenants by a ceremony that involved cutting sacrificial animals in half. The parties to the covenant walked between the two animal halves (cp. [Gen 15:9–18](#)) to symbolize their commitment to be cut in two like the sacrifice if one violated the terms of the covenant. Covenants also were written documents, sometimes chiseled in stone and set up in a public area for all to see and remember (see study note on [Josh 8:32](#)). • In Israel, a binding oath was sworn in the name of the Lord. Violating the oath invited the Lord's judgment for swearing falsely ([Exod 20:7](#)).

Joshua 9:16

lived nearby! In reporting Israel's discovery, the author repeated the word the Israelites had used to voice their suspicion of the Gibeonites ([9:7](#)).

Joshua 9:17

Gibeon, Kephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-jearim were on the plateau northwest of Jerusalem and southwest of Bethel and Ai (see study note on 7:2).

Joshua 9:18–21

Israel was not entitled to break this treaty even though the Gibeonites deceived the Israelites into making it. Breaking a covenant sworn by an oath in the presence of the Lord would have made light of God's name and honor (cp. [Gen 27:30–38](#)).

Joshua 9:22

As the leader of Israel, Joshua was within his rights when he called together the Gibeonites to question them. • you live right here among us? Joshua's use of this phrase tacitly acknowledged that he should not have accepted the word of the Gibeonites without consulting the Lord.

Joshua 9:23

The Gibeonites were cursed, meaning they were diminished to the status of servants. • At that time, the house of . . . God was the Tabernacle; later, it was the Temple at Jerusalem.

Joshua 9:24–25

The response of the Gibeonites amounted to a statement of faith in the Lord: They acted deceptively because they believed that God would enable Israel to conquer Canaan.

Joshua 9:26–27

This summary closes the account of Joshua's second and last major mistake in leadership. • to this day: See study note on 4:9.

Joshua 10:1

Adoni-zedek means "master of righteousness" or "my master is righteous." An earlier king of Jerusalem named Melchizedek ("king of righteousness" or "my king is righteous") had been "a priest of God Most High" and a friend of Abraham ([Gen 14:18–20](#)). However, Adoni-zedek was not a friend to Joshua or a believer in the Lord.

Joshua 10:1–43

Gibeon and its neighboring cities occupied a plateau north of Jerusalem (see study note on 7:2). With Gibeon now allied to Israel, control of the plateau and of the central hill country in the vicinity of Gibeon belonged to Israel. Throughout history, whoever has controlled the plateau has, in general, also controlled the hill country. The Canaanite kings had to conquer Gibeon or their cause was lost.

Joshua 10:2

Gibeon was apparently not one of the royal cities. Gibeon might have been subservient to Canaan-controlled Jerusalem before making the covenant with Joshua, or it might have been an independent town controlled by a few leading families.

Joshua 10:5

When the Old Testament makes a distinction between Amorites and Canaanites (see study note on 3:10), the Amorite kings controlled the hill country, while the Canaanites occupied the valleys and the coastal plain.

Joshua 10:7

Joshua had sworn to rescue Gibeon, so now he set out to do it.

Joshua 10:8

God once again urged Joshua not to be afraid, assuring him of victory over Israel's enemies (see also [1:9](#); [8:1](#)).

Joshua 10:9

Joshua's army walked all night to travel the fifteen miles up the rugged passes and steep slopes and across the plateau. By attacking the Amorite armies from the east at sunrise, Joshua's army came out of the sun, blinding the Amorites as they faced eastward to fight. • Israel's covenant required the nation to respond to Gibeon's plea for help, but Joshua responded more promptly than any treaty

required. Defeating the Canaanite force with a swift strike gave Israel a tremendous advantage.

Joshua 10:10

It was about forty miles from Gibeon, down the Beth-horon road, then south through the western foothills to Azekah and Makkedah.

Joshua 10:10–13

Three miracles—supernatural panic, a terrible hailstorm, and a lengthened day—demonstrated that the destruction of the Canaanites was entirely God’s doing.

Joshua 10:12

Joshua prayed to have the day lengthened so the Israelites could finish the task without allowing the Amorite forces time to organize a new defense against Israel. • The sun and moon, two of Canaan’s most powerful gods, proved powerless against the Lord. • Aijalon was a city near the western end of the Beth-horon road.

Joshua 10:13

God caused the sun to stay in the middle of the sky. Not all miracles can be understood, whether in purpose, in scope, or in mechanism. • The Book of Jashar served as one of the ancient sources for Israel’s historians. While well known in ancient Israel, it did not survive as a separate document.

Joshua 10:16

The five kings had led the southern coalition against God’s people. • Although the location of Makkedah is uncertain, it was in the same district as Lachish ([15:39–41](#)) in the southern part of the western foothills, about twenty-five miles southwest of Jerusalem. Limestone caves are numerous in that region.

Joshua 10:18–19

By blocking the opening of the cave, Joshua reduced the number of guards needed to keep the kings from escaping. This also eliminated danger to the guards and freed more men to pursue the fleeing people.

Joshua 10:21

The armies returned safely, indicating that Israel suffered few or no casualties in this battle, a sign of God’s presence in the battle. • no one dared: The Canaanites in the south now had firsthand experience that Israel’s powerful God was fighting them.

Joshua 10:24

Victorious commanders in the ancient Near East would commonly put their feet on defeated kings’ necks to symbolize their subjugation.

Joshua 10:25

Joshua encouraged his men at Makkedah, using the same words God had used to encourage him before Israel crossed the Jordan and again before the battle of Ai ([1:9](#); [8:1](#)).

Joshua 10:26–27

Joshua’s execution of the five kings followed the pattern established with the king of Ai (see note on [8:29](#)).

Joshua 10:28

He destroyed them all: See study note on 2:9–10.

Joshua 10:28–39

Joshua led the Israelites throughout southern Canaan, where they captured but did not burn a number of important cities. God had promised that Israel would dwell in cities they had not built ([Deut 6:10](#)).

Joshua 10:29-30

Libnah was probably about six miles north of Lachish. Because the location of Makkedah is uncertain, how far it was from Libnah is also unknown.

Joshua 10:31-33

Lachish, by far the most important of the six cities taken at this time, was defended so well that it took Joshua until the second day to capture it. • Gezer was about twenty-five miles north of Lachish. Lachish and Gezer might have had a mutual aid treaty.

Joshua 10:38-39

Because settlement in the hill country was sparse, the surrounding villages—walled towns that could not maintain their independence—depended on the kingdoms of the dominant cities for protection.

Joshua 10:40

Joshua's southern campaign cleared the way for the southern tribes to occupy this whole region when the settlement process began. • the western foothills: See study note on Deut 1:7.

Joshua 10:41

This Goshen was not the region in Egypt's Nile delta ([Gen 47:27](#)) but a town in the hill country ([Josh 15:51](#)) south of Jerusalem. From Goshen up to Gibeon describes the eastern reach of Joshua's southern campaign.

Joshua 10:43

Joshua and his army were free to return to their camp at Gilgal in the Jordan Valley and turn their thoughts to the northern region of Canaan.

Joshua 11:1-3

Hazor lay along the international trade route and was by far the largest and most important inland city of Canaan (see [11:10](#)). • Virtually all of northern Canaan joined the coalition of King Jabin against Israel. This region stretched from the Mediterranean Sea in the west to the desert in the east and from the borders of Phoenicia in the north to the hill country and the Jordan Valley in the south. • The term Jebusites typically refers to the people of Jerusalem and surrounding towns under its control. Perhaps men from Jebus were mercenaries to Jabin. • Mizpah means "watchtower" or "lookout." Several places had this name; this one was the extensive region of the lower slopes of Mount Hermon, the highest peak of the Promised Land.

Joshua 11:1-16

Through the more detailed accounts of Joshua's campaign in southern Canaan (chs [6-10](#)), the narrator established firmly that the Israelites needed God's help to succeed. Because what had been true in the southern campaign would also be true in the northern campaign (ch [11](#)), those details were unnecessary here.

Joshua 11:4

In the ancient Near East at this time, horses only pulled chariots; cavalry and mounted bowmen did not appear until centuries later. • Israel probably faced chariots for the first time in this battle against the northern coalition, where the land was flatter than in southern Canaan. As the heavy weapons of the battlefield, chariots easily overpowered foot soldiers. Scythes were often attached to the axles, and charioteers drove at opposing infantry to mow them down.

Joshua 11:5

The location of Merom is unclear. The most likely site was in Upper Galilee a few miles west of Hazor.

Joshua 11:6

God again urged Joshua not to be afraid, promising Israel the victory, even against horses and chariots.

- cripple their horses and burn their chariots: God wanted Israel to rely on him rather than weaponry and equipment (cp. [Deut 17:16](#); [Isa 31:1](#)).

Joshua 11:7

Joshua . . . traveled: Jabin might have planned to move from Merom out of Upper Galilee to meet Israel on a more advantageous battlefield when all his forces were assembled. However, Joshua attacked suddenly, before Jabin could choose the battleground.

Joshua 11:8

The Canaanites scattered widely, fleeing north and west into the territory of Greater Sidon on the Mediterranean coast and eastward into the valley of Mizpah.

Joshua 11:11

completely destroyed: Archaeological excavation confirms that the city of Hazor was destroyed by fire during this period.

Joshua 11:13

the towns built on mounds: In the ancient Near East it was common practice to rebuild cities on the same sites after they had been destroyed. All the elements that made a city site advantageous remained after a city's destruction. Many cities were rebuilt numerous times, slowly rising in height as more debris accumulated after each destruction.

- Joshua burned only Hazor in the north, just as he had destroyed Jericho ([6:24](#)) and Ai ([8:28](#)) in the center of the land.

Joshua 11:15

God commanded Joshua to exercise faithfulness to Moses' torah, or "Book of Instruction" ([1:7–10](#)). At the conclusion of the two major campaigns to

occupy Canaan, the narrator reported that Joshua had obeyed all the commands faithfully.

Joshua 11:18

Although the initial victories in both the southern and the northern campaigns were quick and decisive, it took a long time to take fortified cities. After Israel crossed the Jordan River, the total campaign for Canaan lasted perhaps five years (see [14:10](#)).

Joshua 11:19–20

The judgment on Canaan was God's, not Israel's. God had extended mercy to the Canaanites for several generations. However, God determined that "the sins of the Amorites" now "warrant their destruction" ([Gen 15:16](#)), and he hardened their hearts. God used Israel as the instrument and agent of his judgment, just as in later centuries God used other nations to execute judgment upon Israel and Judah for their sins.

Joshua 11:21–22

the descendants of Anak: See [Num 13:28, 33](#).

Joshua 11:23

The major theme of the second half of Joshua is dividing the land.

- rest: See study note on 1:13.

Joshua 12:1

The Arnon River flows into the Dead Sea midway down its eastern side, creating the Arnon Gorge. Israel began its conquests here (see [Num 21:13–15, 21–35](#)).

- Mount Hermon lies twenty-five miles north-northeast of the Sea of Galilee.

Joshua 12:1–24

This chapter summarizes Israel's conquests on both sides of the Jordan and transitions to Joshua's distribution of the land of Canaan among the tribes of Israel (ch [13](#)).

Joshua 12:2

King Sihon (see [Num 21:24-25](#)) had controlled the northern Jordan Valley as far as the Sea of Galilee but not the northern part of Gilead ([Josh 12:5](#)).

Joshua 12:3

Beth-jeshimoth was Israel's camp in the plains of Moab ([Num 33:49](#)). • Moses had viewed the Promised Land from Pisgah ([Deut 34:1](#)).

Joshua 12:4

King Og of Bashan: See [Num 21:33-35](#). • The Rephaites were an indigenous people who lived on both sides of the Jordan. Many scholars have concluded that the Rephaites were unusually tall (see [Deut 3:11](#)). • Ashtaroah and Edrei: Many rulers of large kingdoms had palaces in more than one of their cities. The fact that Joshua credits only Og with more than one capital indicates that his kingdom was much larger than others Israel encountered, except for Sihon's.

Joshua 12:6

Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: See [Num 32](#). The author of Joshua reminded the Israelites that their kin who lived east of the Jordan also belonged to Israel.

Joshua 12:7

Baal-gad was at the western foot of Mount Hermon, the northern limit of Joshua's conquests west of the Jordan. • The valley of Lebanon divided the coastal Lebanon range and the inland Anti-Lebanon range. • Mount Halak, which leads up to Seir (i.e., Edom), marked the southern limit of Joshua's conquests.

Joshua 12:7-24

Joshua and the Israelite armies faithfully carried out the tasks God gave them. This summary showcases their successes, providing proper recognition for their faithfulness. God gave the

Israelites their promised inheritance while bringing about the long-delayed judgment of the Canaanites. This roster of defeated kings, identified by their city-states, provides evidence of God's accomplished purposes. A solemn yet joyful recital for Israel, the list symbolizes God's mighty acts for his people and exalts his own great name.

Joshua 12:8

Hittites . . . Jebusites: See study note on 3:10.

Joshua 13:1-7

Israel did not conquer the entire land of Canaan while Joshua was alive. The unconquered areas, lying mostly in the valleys and plains, were the most populous regions. Several generations passed before Israel became strong enough to absorb or subjugate these regions and their peoples.

Joshua 13:1-21.45

As he had promised, God brought Israel into the land. Joshua next turned his attention to the allotment of the land to Israel's tribes. • The tribal allotments gave geographical reality to the Israelites' covenant with God and expressed the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Because God owned the land, the apportionment to the tribes was a gift. God gave them the land to dwell in and directed its distribution. • In these lists of tribal allotments, the author describes some borders in such detail that they can be plotted on a map while others were far less well defined.

Joshua 13:2

The Philistines were one of several groups in the great migration of the Sea Peoples from the Aegean region within a few decades after Israel's entry into Canaan. They settled along the southwestern Mediterranean coast, west and southwest of Judah. They came from Caphtor or Crete ([Deut 2:23](#); [Amos 9:7](#)). • These Geshurites were people from a southern territory, not the northern Geshurites (cp. [Josh 12:5](#)).

Joshua 13:3

The stream of Shihor probably marked the traditional boundary between Canaan and Egypt, bisecting the northern Sinai Peninsula. • The Philistine territory included five main cities: Gaza, Ashdod, and Ashkelon were on the Mediterranean coast, and Gath and Ekron were a few miles inland. • The Philistines displaced the Avvites ([Deut 2:23](#)).

Joshua 13:4-6

The Sidonians (that is, Phoenicians; see [Isa 23:11](#); [Obad 1:20](#); [Acts 11:19](#)) lived in the north along the coast, from north of Mount Carmel to above Gebal (Byblos). They also apparently occupied the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon mountain ranges. Sidon was the dominant Phoenician city when Israel entered Canaan.

Joshua 13:6-7

The lands just listed had not yet been conquered, but God directed Joshua to show his faith by allotting them to the tribes against the future, when they would be taken.

Joshua 13:8-14

Half the tribe of Manasseh and the tribes of Reuben and Gad had asked Moses for their inheritance on the east side of the Jordan in the land that had been the kingdoms of Sihon and Og ([Num 21:21-35](#); [32:1-42](#)). In return, they had helped the rest of Israel take possession of their inheritance west of the Jordan ([Josh 1:12-18](#); [4:12-13](#)). Here, the author confirmed their possession of these lands.

Joshua 13:14

The tribe of Levi inherited no tribal land of its own (see [Deut 18:1-8](#)). Levitical cities were located in the territories of the other tribes ([Josh 21](#)).

Joshua 13:15-23

Because Reuben, Jacob's firstborn son by Leah ([Gen 29:32](#)), forfeited his birthright by sleeping with his father's concubine ([Gen 35:22](#)), the inheritance of

his tribe was not of central importance. Although the tribe received a fertile portion of land, it was difficult to defend from neighboring nations. The tribe of Reuben eventually lost the southern portion to Moab.

Joshua 13:21

The leaders of Midian were apparently kings ([Num 31:8](#)) or sheiks of small city-states south of Sihon's kingdom. The nomadic Midianites depended mostly on sheep and goats for their livelihood.

Joshua 13:22

Balaam, son of Beor: He created a plan to lead Israel into the worship of false gods (idolatry) through sexual sin ([Numbers 31:16](#)). God had forbidden *Balaam* from cursing Israel ([Numbers 22-25](#)).

Joshua 13:24-28

Gad was Jacob's seventh son, born to Zilpah, Leah's servant. Just as Gad's position in his family was peripheral, the tribe of Gad was peripheral to Israel.

Joshua 13:29-33

Manasseh was Joseph's elder son. Jacob gave Joseph's sons each a full inheritance, thus giving Joseph a double portion of the birthright (see [14:4](#)).

Joshua 13:30-31

Jair was a great-grandson of Manasseh ([1 Chr 2:21-22](#)). Makir was one of Manasseh's sons. It is unclear whether the land allotted to these tribes in north Gilead was distinguished from the land that the tribe of Gad received there.

Joshua 14:1

Eleazar . . . Joshua . . . and the tribal leaders supervised the distribution of the land to ensure that the process was honest and just.

Joshua 14:1–19:51

The allotment of land to the tribes on the west side of the Jordan describes what God intended for each tribe to possess. • The narrator frames this section with the assignment of land to Caleb at the beginning ([14:6–15](#)) and to Joshua at the end ([19:49–51](#)). Only Caleb and Joshua had expressed faith in God that Israel could conquer the land ([Num 13:30](#); [14:6–9](#)).

Joshua 14:2

sacred lots: See study note on 7:16–18.

Joshua 14:4

Joseph, the elder son of Jacob's favorite wife Rachel, received a double portion of land through his sons Manasseh and Ephraim (see study note on Gen 48:5–7). Because the Levites did not receive a separate tribal territory ([Josh 13:14](#)), the total number of tribes with land remained at twelve.

Joshua 14:6

The Kenizzite people were not originally Israelites ([Gen 15:19](#)); how they became attached to Judah is unknown. • about you and me: Only Caleb and Joshua were faithful to God at the first opportunity to enter the land, so God promised them that they would possess it ([Num 14:24](#)).

Joshua 14:9

Moses . . . promised: See [Num 14:24](#).

Joshua 14:11

Caleb judged himself to be as strong at eighty-five as he had been at forty. He still felt equipped to travel and fight—to continue both ordinary and extraordinary pursuits.

Joshua 14:12

Israel had stayed out of Canaan forty-five years earlier because they feared the descendants of

Anak, a tall, strong people who lived in the hill country of Judah ([Num 13:32–33](#)).

Joshua 14:15

rest from war: See study note on 1:13.

Joshua 15:1–63

Judah's tribal allotment is described in greater detail than that of the other tribes. The failures of Judah's elder brothers ([Gen 34:25–31](#); [35:22](#)) put him in line to receive the mantle of leadership. Thus, the tribe of Judah received a central geographical position among the tribes, guaranteeing its leadership in the nation ([Gen 49:8–12](#); [Deut 33:7](#)).

Joshua 15:2–4

Judah's southern boundary extended well into the desert of the Negev, which had little if any settled population throughout the Old Testament period.

Joshua 15:5–11

Although Judah's northern boundary is described in great detail, some sections of this border cannot be determined with certainty.

Joshua 15:7

This Debir was not the same town as the Debir/Kiriath-sepher of [15:15](#). • This Gilgal was not the same Gilgal where the Israelites earlier established their camp ([4:19](#)).

Joshua 15:8

The valley of Ben-Hinnom marked Judah's northern border. Jerusalem occupied a ridge rising northward from the lower end of this valley within the tribe of Benjamin's territory. Neither tribe occupied Jerusalem, so when David captured it, it became the royal city of his dynasty rather than just another tribal city.

Joshua 15:9

the spring at the waters of Nephtoah: It is possible that the place name is a reference to Egyptian Pharaoh Merneptah (late 1200s BC); an Egyptian papyrus refers to the “wells of Merneptah” on the mountain ridges of Canaan.

Joshua 15:12

These were the boundaries of Judah when the settlement process began. Later, the tribes of Simeon and Dan received their allotments from some of Judah’s southern and western territories, and within a few decades the Philistines came from the Greek islands, settling all the southern coastal plain allotted to Judah (see study note on 13:2).

Joshua 15:16

Cp. [1 Sam 17:25](#); [18:27](#).

Joshua 15:17

Othniel, Caleb’s nephew, became Israel’s first judge ([Judg 3:9–11](#)).

Joshua 15:18–19

What’s the matter? No water source existed for the town Othniel conquered. Negev means “dry land.”

- The upper and lower springs were close together but too far from Debir to belong to it naturally, so Acsah asked for the rights to the water.

Joshua 15:20–63

Not all of these locations can be identified with certainty. Many are unknown except for their occurrence in this and other lists. Some receive passing reference in other texts.

Joshua 15:21

in the extreme south: Or *in the Negev* (see study note on 1:4). The Hebrew word negeb can refer either to the general direction (“south”) or the desert region named “Negev.” • The location of

Eder is otherwise unknown. Some propose translating this word as “Arad” because Arad should be about here in the list and was too important to have been left out. This translation would simply reverse two Hebrew letters that are very similar in shape.

Joshua 15:33

From the perspective of the highlanders of the Judean hill country, the lower hills between them and the coastal plain were the western foothills. These hills were separated geologically from the hill country by a series of north–south valleys. In this list, the western foothills are divided into four districts.

Joshua 15:45–47

The fourth district of the western foothills included most of the territory soon to be occupied by the Philistines—the tribe of Judah held it only briefly.

Joshua 15:48

The hill country was in the central highlands of Judah from Jerusalem in the north to just past Debir ([15:15](#)) in the south. It was divided into five districts.

Joshua 15:56

This Jezreel in Judah was not the northern Jezreel. This city was the hometown of Ahinoam, David’s wife and the mother of his eldest son, Amnon ([2 Sam 3:2](#)).

Joshua 15:59

Following this verse, the Greek Old Testament includes another district of 11 cities: Tekoa, Ephrathah (that is, Bethlehem), Phagor, Etam, Kulon, Tatam, Saris, Kareem, Gallim, Bether, Manoch—eleven towns with their surrounding villages. The inclusion of this district accounts for Bethlehem; this town’s omission would be surprising. Perhaps an early copyist of the Hebrew text accidentally omitted this twelfth district.

Joshua 15:61

The wilderness of Judea included the eastern slopes of the central mountain highlands and extended to the western shore of the Dead Sea; three of its six towns were on or near that shoreline.

Joshua 15:63

Even though Jerusalem was assigned to the tribe of Benjamin ([18:28](#)), it was not conquered in Joshua's day. • to this day: The Jebusites' continued presence later caused Judah trouble ([Judg 1:21](#)).

Joshua 16:1

Jericho was assigned to the tribe of Benjamin ([18:21](#)).

Joshua 16:1-17:18

Joseph had two sons, Manasseh and Ephraim ([Gen 41:50-52](#)). Half of Manasseh's descendants had received their inheritance east of the Jordan River. The tribe of Ephraim and the rest of the tribe of Manasseh now received their allotments. This brought the total number of allotments to twelve and fulfilled the blessing Jacob had pronounced upon Joseph ([Gen 49:22-26](#)). Like Judah in the south, Joseph's tribes exercised leadership from their central position in the north.

Joshua 16:3

Ephraim's border followed the ascent from lower to upper Beth-horon (see [16:5](#)), giving this tribe control of one of the two main roads to Jerusalem from the west. • Gezer, a large and important Canaanite town at the juncture of the coastal plain and the hill country, apparently did not come into Israel's possession until the time of Solomon (see [Judg 1:29](#); [1 Kgs 9:16](#)).

Joshua 16:5-8

This description of Ephraim's northern boundary with Manasseh is general and incomplete. Because Shechem belonged to Manasseh, the border between the two tribes ran south of that town.

Joshua 17:1

See [13:29-33](#) and study note.

Joshua 17:3-6

In ancient Israel, inheritance usually passed from a father to his sons. Without sons, a man's name could pass into oblivion. However, Zelophehad's daughters had petitioned Moses, Moses had inquired of God, and God had ruled that they should inherit their father's portion (see [Num 27:1-11](#)). God's ruling established a general principle, declaring that no family would be excluded from a portion of God's material blessings.

Joshua 17:7

Asher was north-northwest of Manasseh, across the Jezreel Valley.

Joshua 17:7-13

As with the tribe of Ephraim, Manasseh's territory was defined by a general description of its borders.

Joshua 17:8-10

This general description of Manasseh's southern border with the land given to the tribe of Ephraim provides more detail than the description of Ephraim's northern border in [16:8](#).

Joshua 17:11-13

All the towns mentioned here except Endor were important, but the military strength of the Canaanites prevented the tribe of Manasseh from inhabiting them for a time.

Joshua 17:13

Throughout the period of the judges and beyond, the Israelites gradually grew stronger and the Canaanite people weaker. After the time of Joshua, the Israelites forced the Canaanites to work as slaves. They eventually absorbed these people and were influenced to worship the Canaanite gods. This idolatry ultimately cost them the land.

Joshua 17:14

Joseph's one portion is described in [16:1-4](#). The descendants of Ephraim and Manasseh received portions that, when combined, were larger than the allotment of any other tribe.

Joshua 17:15

The Perizzites lived in Canaan when Israel's conquest began. • Rephaites: See study note on 12:4; see also [Deut 2:10-11](#), [20-21](#); [3:11](#).

Joshua 17:16

As a result of the Canaanites' iron chariots, Ephraim and Manasseh were restricted to the hill country in the early part of the settlement period (see study note on 11:4). • The valley of Jezreel, a geological interruption of the hill country, separated Lower Galilee to the north from the hill country of Manasseh to the south. The Canaanites living in and near it and the valley of Beth-shan restricted Manasseh's expansion and apparently Ephraim's as well. Most of the towns named in [17:11](#) were on the edges of these valleys.

Joshua 17:17-18

Rather than rebuke the people for their fear, Joshua repeated his instructions to clear forest land for settlement. His promise that the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh would eventually drive out the Canaanites gave them a hope by which they could enlarge their faith and conquer their fear. • Much of the hill country was forested, and Canaanite settlement was sparse there. If Ephraim and Manasseh had contented themselves with land already cleared, they would have had little room for settlement. With the introduction of iron

technology at about this time, including iron axe heads, the people of these tribes could clear the virgin forests and open up new land for settlement. Joshua might have set an example by being the first to clear his own homestead at Timnath-serah ([19:50](#)), a forested region in the Ephraimite hill country.

Joshua 18:1

Israel had been encamped at Gilgal in the Jordan Valley ([14:6](#)). Shiloh was about twenty miles north of Jerusalem, in the hill country of Ephraim. By setting up the Tabernacle there, Joshua made Shiloh Israel's religious and political center. The Tabernacle remained at Shiloh until the Philistines captured the Ark ([1 Sam 4:10-11](#)).

Joshua 18:4

The three selected representatives from each tribe came from the seven tribes that had not yet received their allotments. • a written report: Israel was not an entirely oral society. If an event or record was important enough to be remembered over time, leaders ordered that it be written down.

Joshua 18:5

The remaining land was divided into seven sections, one for each tribe not yet assigned its territory.

Joshua 18:6

Joshua publicly cast sacred lots to eliminate envy or suspicion (see also study note on 7:16-18).

Joshua 18:7

The Levites: See ch [21](#). • Gad . . . Manasseh: See [13:15-33](#).

Joshua 18:9

The Canaanites of the hill country now feared Israel and allowed twenty-one men ([18:4](#)) to walk

through these territories and return unharmed. • The written record was probably a scroll, which might have provided the original source for the descriptions of the tribal allotments in chs [18–19](#).

Joshua 18:11

Benjamin was Jacob's twelfth and last son, and the second son of Rachel, Jacob's favorite wife. The land received by his descendants reflected this favored position; they received a small but central portion between . . . Judah and Joseph.

Joshua 18:21–28

While Judah's land included eleven or twelve districts (see study note on 15:59), the tribe of Benjamin had two, totaling twenty-six towns. However, the location between the lands of Judah and Joseph gave Benjamin an economic and military importance significantly greater than its size.

Joshua 18:28

Jerusalem: See study note on 15:8. • Kiriath: The Kiriath-jearim of [18:14](#) belonged to Judah; another town with this name might have existed but is otherwise unknown. The word *Kiriath* here was probably originally followed by a word that has been lost in the process of copying.

Joshua 19:1

Simeon, Jacob and Leah's second son, was older than Judah. However, he had forfeited a leading role with his violent actions against Shechem ([Gen 34:25–26](#)). The tribal inheritance of his descendants reflected this; their land was carved out of Judah's territory on the southern periphery of the Negev. This arid land was far from any centers of influence and power.

Joshua 19:2–9

Some of the towns given to the tribe of Simeon were also part of Judah's allocation because Judah's territory was too large for them (cp. [17:14–18](#)). Judah apparently absorbed most of Simeon's

territory into its own before the end of the Old Testament period.

Joshua 19:10–16

The tribe of Zebulun received land partly in the valley of Jezreel and partly in the hills of Lower Galilee.

Joshua 19:10–23

The lands given to the tribes of Zebulun and Issachar were strategically located; the major international trading route from Egypt to Mesopotamia ran through their territories. When Israel was strong, this position brought prosperity. However, when Israel was weak, these tribes were vulnerable both to the armies of Egypt and to the successive Mesopotamian powers that fought for control of the ancient Near East.

Joshua 19:10–48

The five small remaining tribes received land on the edges of the Israelite territory and had little national influence.

Joshua 19:13

Gath-hepher was the hometown of the prophet Jonah ([2 Kgs 14:25](#)).

Joshua 19:15

This Bethlehem was not the birthplace of David and Jesus in Judah. • More than twelve towns are named; some apparently did not belong to Zebulun but were on its borders.

Joshua 19:16

Both by number of towns and by size of its territory, Zebulun was smallest of all the tribes. However, the New Testament village of Nazareth, where Jesus grew up, was in the tribal territory of Zebulun ([Matt 2:19–23](#); [4:13–16](#)).

Joshua 19:17-23

The land given to the tribe of Issachar included much of the fertile Jezreel Valley. During Old Testament times, this valley was largely a swamp surrounded by prosperous and important cities. This area was a center of Canaanite strength, so this small tribe had trouble gaining a foothold at first.

Joshua 19:24-31

The land allocated to the tribe of Asher included the Plain of Acco on the Mediterranean coast and western Galilee. To the southwest, Asher touched Carmel, sharing at least a short common border with land allotted to the tribe of Manasseh. To the north, the Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon limited Asher's expansion.

Joshua 19:30

The twenty-two towns did not include Tyre and Sidon, which the nation of Israel never controlled.

Joshua 19:32-39

The tribe of Naphtali occupied eastern Galilee and overlooked the Sea of Galilee. Because a branch of an international trade route from Egypt to Mesopotamia ran through the territory of Naphtali, this tribe enjoyed periods of prosperity when Israel's kings were strong. The city of Hazor was within Naphtali's territory, guarding a section of that route. Naphtali is mentioned in [Matt 4:13-16](#) in connection with Jesus' ministry in Galilee.

Joshua 19:40-48

The original allotment given to the tribe of Dan lay west of Judah and southwest of Ephraim's main territory, between Judah and Philistia.

Joshua 19:43

About fifty years after Israel came into Canaan under Joshua, the Philistines moved into the southern coastal plain and occupied the cities of Timnah and Ekron ([Judg 14:1-2](#); [1 Sam 5:1-10](#)). The Philistines were among the Sea Peoples who

had perhaps been driven out of the Greek mainland and the Greek islands by an invasion from the north. The Sea Peoples also invaded and destroyed the Hittite Empire to the north of Israel. (Some scholars think that Homer's *Iliad* reflects this movement.)

Joshua 19:47

The tribe of Dan had trouble taking possession of their land because of the Philistines, so a group of Danites later moved northward to Laish (see [Judg 18](#)), which they renamed Dan, on the northern border of Israel's territory.

Joshua 19:49-50

The piece of land given to Joshua closes the section on the allocation of land to the tribes of Israel (see study note on 14:1-19:51).

Joshua 19:51

After Joshua received his inheritance, the division of the land was completed. Joshua served God and led Israel faithfully for many years, and God was gracious to Joshua.

Joshua 20:1-6

These verses contain a review of the law concerning cities of refuge (see also [Num 35:6-34](#)).

Joshua 20:1-21.45

Before the land was fully allotted, Joshua needed to establish six cities of refuge and assign cities for the Levites to live in.

Joshua 20:3

The relatives of a murder or manslaughter victim had the responsibility of seeking revenge for the death. If the avenger (Hebrew *go'el*) found the killer outside a city of refuge, he could kill him without punishment.

Joshua 20:7-9

Joshua designated six cities of refuge: three on the east side of the Jordan, and three on the west. From anywhere in the land, one of these six well-known Levitical cities was no more than two days' travel away.

Joshua 20:9

The treatment of foreigners in Israel was a great advance in human relations. Resident aliens were to receive every justice offered to native Israelites (see [Exod 22:21](#); [Lev 19:33-34](#); [24:22](#); [Num 15:15-16](#)).

Joshua 21:1-8

The towns given to the tribe of Levi were determined by lot (see study note on 7:16-18) by Israel's leaders.

Joshua 21:2-3

The Lord commanded Moses: See [Num 35:1-7](#). One of the priestly duties was to teach God's torah (see study note on 1:8) to Israel. The Levites could accomplish this better by living throughout the tribal territories.

Joshua 21:4

The descendants of Aaron served as Israel's priests. The cities they received were allotted by sacred lots. The priestly towns were in the tribal territories closest to Jerusalem, where the Temple was later built.

Joshua 21:5

The remaining families of the Kohathite clan received cities in the central part of the hill country, north of Jerusalem.

Joshua 21:6

The clan of Gershon received cities among the four northernmost tribes in Israel.

Joshua 21:7

The clan of Merari did not stay together as other Levitical clans did.

Joshua 21:8

The pasturelands were grazing ground surrounding the cities. The repetition of this word throughout the list ([21:8-42](#)) gave the allotment the character of a legal record, guaranteeing the Levites access to lands immediately surrounding each of the Levitical cities ([Num 35:4-5](#)).

Joshua 21:9-42

The descendants of Aaron received thirteen cities, the rest of the Kohathite clan received ten, the descendants of Gershon received thirteen, and the Merari clan received twelve. There were a total of forty-eight Levitical cities. Each tribe had four Levitical cities, except Judah had eight, Simeon had one, and Naphtali had three. Six of the Levitical cities were also cities of refuge ([20:7-8](#)).

Joshua 21:45

God had made Israel many good promises, and not one had failed. He kept his promise to give Israel possession of the land and to save them from their surrounding enemies.

Joshua 22:1-34

Joshua's first farewell was to the tribes east of the Jordan as he sent them home. Characteristically, he exhorted them to remain faithful.

Joshua 22:1-24.33

Israel completed the conquest and allotment of the land, but much of the hard work of actually settling it still lay ahead. However, all that remained for Joshua in his role as leader of Israel was to say farewell.

Joshua 22:2-3

Joshua commended the eastern tribes for their faithful obedience and the fulfillment of their promise to help the rest of Israel inhabit Canaan (see [1:12-18](#); [Num 32:1-32](#)).

Joshua 22:4-6

Joshua's words recall God's words to Joshua at the beginning of the conquest ([1:1-9](#)). In order to live in the land, Israel needed to be faithful to God by being very careful to obey all the commands and the instructions given to Moses.

Joshua 22:5

all your heart and all your soul: See [Deut 6:5](#).

Joshua 22:7

Moses had given: The author takes great care to emphasize that the tribes east of the Jordan were part of Israel.

Joshua 22:8

The great wealth represented these tribes' share of the spoils from the cities Israel had taken. • Share . . . with your relatives: While most of the fighting men assisted the rest of Israel, some men had remained to protect the women, children, and herds.

Joshua 22:10

to a place called Geliloth: It is reasonable to presume that Geliloth and the altar were on the west bank of the Jordan.

Joshua 22:10-20

Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh built their own altar, triggering a confrontation with the rest of Israel.

Joshua 22:11

The tribes referred to here as the rest of Israel (literally *the sons of Israel*) consisted of the tribes given land west of the Jordan River, in Canaan proper. They already referred to themselves as Israel, excluding the tribes east of the Jordan.

Joshua 22:12

The western tribes were ready to go to war because they saw the altar as violating [Lev 17:8-9](#) and [Deut 13:12-15](#).

Joshua 22:13-14

delegation: See [Deut 13:14](#). • The ten tribes west of the Jordan included Ephraim and the western half of Manasseh but not the tribe of Levi.

Joshua 22:15

The delegation crossed the Jordan River to meet the leaders of the eastern tribes in the land of Gilead, probably in southern Gad.

Joshua 22:15-20

The direct and hard-hitting statements and questions of the delegation made sure that God's wrath would not come upon the nation because of rebellion like Achan's ([7:1-15](#)) or the episode at Peor ([Num 25](#)).

Joshua 22:16

The delegation brought the message the ten tribes had agreed upon when they met at Shiloh. • The whole community of the Lord demands to know (literally *Thus says the whole congregation of the Lord*): The formula using "thus says" was a typical introduction to a messenger's report (e.g., [Ezra 1:2](#); [Isa 28:16](#)).

Joshua 22:17

The sin at Peor was Israel's idolatrous rebellion in Moab, just at the point of entering the Promised

Land ([Num 25](#)). Phinehas, now the leader of this delegation, had acted to save Israel from complete destruction at that time. He did not want to see any part of Israel turn away from God again.

Joshua 22:19

Being defiled was not necessarily the result of rebellion or a moral lapse, but it did prevent persons or groups from participating in regular worship activities, including the offering of sacrifices. If the eastern tribes had defiled the land itself, the Israelites could not offer sacrifices to the Lord within it. This concern provides evidence that the eastern tribes had built their altar on the western bank of the Jordan. • The land west of the Jordan was considered the Lord's land. The delegation from the western tribes made a very generous offer, inviting the eastern tribes to share their land. This demonstrated their commitment to national unity in faithfulness to God.

Joshua 22:20

Achan: See [ch 7](#). The delegation of western tribes feared that Achan's sin and its consequences would be repeated.

Joshua 22:21-34

The eastern tribes defended their action.

Joshua 22:22

The Lord . . . is God! The two-fold repetition of this dramatic affirmation indicated how shocked the eastern tribes were when accused of rebellion.

Joshua 22:23

The eastern tribes swore by the name of the Lord that they were not guilty. • The instructions for sacrifices prescribed burnt offerings or grain offerings or peace offerings ([Lev 1-3](#)). At this time, Israel's worship was centered at the Tabernacle in Shiloh. To offer sacrifices anywhere but the central sanctuary was a violation of God's covenant.

Joshua 22:24-29

The eastern tribes feared exclusion from Israel at a later time because the Jordan River divided them from the western tribes.

Joshua 22:27

The altar near the bank of the Jordan would stand as a memorial (literally *witness*) through the generations that the eastern tribes were also part of Israel.

Joshua 22:28

This altar was a copy, intended to be seen, not used.

Joshua 22:31

you have rescued: In his reply to the eastern tribes, Phinehas used very similar language to the words God had spoken when Phinehas turned God's anger from Israel at Peor ([Num 25:11](#)).

Joshua 22:33

Both the eastern and western tribes were relieved that the crisis had been averted, and they joyfully praised God to renew their affirmation of national unity in faithfulness to God.

Joshua 22:34

Witness: Hebrew texts that include this word interpret the last statement as an explanation of the name. Texts that omit the word understand the last quotation to be the name of the altar.

Joshua 23:1-11

Joshua urged Israel's leaders to be faithful.

Joshua 23:2-3

The leaders . . . of Israel had experienced what God had done for them and to their enemies.

Throughout the lifetimes of these leaders who outlived Joshua, Israel continued to be faithful to God ([Judg 2:7](#)).

Joshua 23:4-5

Some of the land that Joshua had assigned to the various tribes remained unconquered. Israel's gradual occupation of the land had an ecological reason (see [Exod 23:29-30](#)), a military reason (see [Judg 1:19](#)), and a theological reason (see [Judg 2:20-3:4](#)). Israel's ensuing unfaithfulness delayed the settlement process by several centuries; instead of driving out the remaining Canaanites, Israel absorbed them, bringing God's people even greater temptations to unfaithfulness. Joshua knew this to be a real danger ([Josh 23:15-16](#)).

Joshua 23:6

Since before crossing the Jordan River to take the land of Canaan, Joshua's guiding principle had been to be very careful to follow everything Moses wrote and not deviate. Now he passed on these instructions to the leaders who would succeed him in leading Israel.

Joshua 23:7

Do not even mention . . . swear by . . . serve . . . or worship them: These four actions describe progressive involvement with idolatry.

Joshua 23:8

To cling tightly or passionately to God would render impotent the temptation to stray off toward other gods. This same verb described a man clinging to his wife ([Gen 2:24](#)) and Ruth clinging to Naomi ([Ruth 1:14](#)).

Joshua 23:9

Examples of great and powerful nations included the Anakim ([11:21-22](#)) and the city of Hazor ([11:10](#)).

Joshua 23:10

God fights for you: Just as God had fought for the Israelites in the past (e.g., [10:11-14](#)), he would continue to fight for them in the future.

Joshua 23:11

be very careful to love: Love is a function of will and intention. Emotion and attraction are the results, not the essence, of love. Because love is (or is not) willed, love can be commanded but not coerced.

Joshua 23:12

Joshua warned God's people not to intermarry with their polytheistic neighbors because such an intimate relationship would lead the Israelites astray ([Deut 7:3-4](#)). However, Canaanites who desired to worship the Lord and join God's people were welcomed ([Josh 6:25](#); [Ruth 4:10](#)). Race, language, and ethnicity had no bearing on God's prohibition of intermarriage; it was a matter of faithfulness to the Lord (cp. [2 Cor 6:14-15](#)).

Joshua 23:12-16

Apostasy—turning away from the true God—is fatal. • Because God is holy, Joshua could speak with optimism regarding God's promises and the good land into which God had brought them. God will not change his holy character even if his people change. The rebellion of God's people cannot damage his holiness, but rebellion will destroy those who rebel.

Joshua 23:13

will no longer drive them out: If Israel associated with the Canaanite remnant, God would oblige the Israelites by not driving out that remnant. God ultimately gives people what they seek.

Joshua 23:15-16

God had blessed the Israelites, and he would also certainly judge them if they turned away from him. Joshua's warning against apostasy was prophetic;

Israel did turn away, and God did not drive out the remaining Canaanites ([Judg 2:20–23](#)).

Joshua 24:1

Shechem was the location of the first affirmation of the covenant shortly after Israel had entered the land of Canaan (see [8:30–35](#) and corresponding study notes).

Joshua 24:1–13

Joshua recounted God's grace toward Israel.

Joshua 24:1–27

In both form and content, this statement of covenant resembled an ancient Near Eastern suzerain-vassal treaty. It begins with a preamble ([24:2](#)) and continues with a historical prologue relating the suzerain's (God's) gracious acts on behalf of the people ([24:3–13](#)), followed by a list of stipulations ([24:14–15](#)) and curses and blessings ([24:19–20](#)). It then notes where the text was to be deposited for periodic reading and renewal (implied, [24:26](#)) and lists witnesses to the covenant ([24:22](#), [27](#)). See also study note on Exod 20:1–23:33.

Joshua 24:2

Terah: See [Gen 11:27–32](#).

Joshua 24:3

Abraham lived at Haran in Mesopotamia beyond the Euphrates with his father Terah ([Gen 11:31–32](#)). • led him into . . . Canaan: See [Gen 12:1–9](#).

Joshua 24:3–13

Israel's faith was always the result of God's initiative. Joshua's repetition of God's words I took . . . I gave . . . I sent . . . I brought reminded the Israelites why they should continue to be loyal to God.

Joshua 24:4

Jacob and Esau: See [Gen 25:19–26](#). • The mountains of Seir stood at the heart of Edom, the homeland of Esau's descendants ([Gen 36:8–9](#)).

Joshua 24:5–7

The Exodus, which culminated with the crossing of the Red Sea, was the climactic salvation event of ancient Israel's history. A number of psalms, several of the later prophets, and several New Testament writers all celebrated this defining event.

Joshua 24:6

Red Sea: See study note on Exod 13:18.

Joshua 24:7

Even though the older Israelites present here had been children at the time of the Exodus, they had seen the events with their very own eyes.

Joshua 24:8

Amorites . . . their land: See [Num 21:21–35](#).

Joshua 24:9–10

See [Num 22–25](#); [31:1–54](#).

Joshua 24:11

See study note on 3:10.

Joshua 24:12

Israel's successes were not because of their swords or bows or other military advantage; all were God's doing.

Joshua 24:13

The Israelites received wealth, including land . . . towns and food, that they had not earned or created.

Joshua 24:14

Put away forever the idols: Israel had not yet broken with the old polytheistic traditions of Mesopotamia beyond the Euphrates River, and some Israelites had added to their supply of gods while living in Egypt.

Joshua 24:15

Joshua threw the influence of his leadership and accomplishments behind his declaration to serve the Lord.

Joshua 24:16

The people responded emphatically, reflecting their determination to follow Joshua's lead in following the Lord.

Joshua 24:16–18

The people recognized that it was God who rescued them, preserved them, and drove out the Amorites.

Joshua 24:19

God is holy: See "God's Absolute Holiness" Theme Note. • God is also jealous; he created every human being for relationship with himself.

Joshua 24:19–24

Joshua pressed the Israelites from a different perspective to underscore the seriousness of their commitment and to ensure that they were not merely responding to the enthusiasm of the moment.

Joshua 24:22

a witness to your own decision: Joshua pressed the people to repeat their declaration as a legal affirmation and commitment.

Joshua 24:23

Some Israelites had continued to worship idols since they left Egypt and after experiencing forty years of God's love and power. Joshua directed them to destroy the idols and turn their hearts to the Lord to serve him alone.

Joshua 24:25

made a covenant: Literally *cut a covenant* (see study note on 9:15).

Joshua 24:26

The Book of God's Instructions was a scroll containing the writings of Moses (see study note on 1:8). It was probably carried to Shiloh and stored with other documents of national importance. • The huge stone was probably a *stela*, a standing stone monument. Joshua might have had a memorial inscription chiseled into this stone monument.

Joshua 24:27

This stone has heard: See study note on 22:27.

Joshua 24:29

Joshua's ancestor Joseph had also attained the age of 110, which was considered the ideal lifespan by ancient Egyptians.

Joshua 24:29–33

The tombs of a venerated ancestor and two revered leaders provided the final notice that Canaan was indeed Israel's land. However, significant work, vigilance, and even fighting still lay ahead.

Joshua 24:30

Timnath-serah: See [19:49-51](#).

Joshua 24:31

Joshua's legacy was so strong that Israel remained faithful to God even throughout the lifetime . . . of the elders who outlived him.

Joshua 24:32

Israel had carried the bones of Joseph out of Egypt, through the years of their journeys, and into Canaan to honor Joseph's last request to be buried in the land God had promised Israel ([Gen 50:25](#); [Exod 13:19](#)). • Shechem was part of the inheritance of Joseph's descendants, at the border between Ephraim and Manasseh. Jacob had purchased the land centuries before for 100 pieces of silver.

Joshua 24:33

Eleazar the high priest had stood beside Joshua during the process of allotting portions of the land to the tribes of Israel. • Joshua, Joseph, and Eleazar were all buried in Ephraim, in the central part of the newly conquered land. Their burial served as a final sign that God had fulfilled his promise to give Israel the land.